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FREE GUIDE

وَإِنَّكَ لَعَلَىٰ خُلُقٍ عَظِيمٍ

"And indeed, you are of a great moral character." (al-Qalam 68:4)

The Character of the Prophet ﷺ

How the Messenger of Allah ﷺ looked, spoke, lived, worshipped and treated people, from the authentic Sunnah.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Before you begin

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>
> **“And indeed, you are of a great moral character.”**
>
> Al-Qalam 68:4.

Saʿd ibn Hishām asked ʿĀʾishah about the character of the Messenger of Allah ﷺ. She said: “Do you not read the Qur’an?” He said yes. She said: “His character was the Qur’an” (Muslim, 746). Everything the Qur’an commands, he lived; everything it forbids, he avoided.

This booklet describes the Prophet ﷺ as his Companions saw him: how he looked, how he spoke, how he lived at home, how he worshipped, how he ate, dressed and slept, and how he treated children, the poor, animals and even his enemies. Every report is from the authentic Sunnah, with its source. The scholars call this subject **ash-Shamāʾil**, and Imām at-Tirmidhī wrote a famous book with that name.

Why learn this?

“There has certainly been for you in the Messenger of Allah an excellent example” (al-Aḥzāb 33:21). We cannot follow someone we do not know.

“None of you truly believes until I am more beloved to him than his father, his child and all people” (al-Bukhārī 15, Muslim 44). Knowing him is the way to loving him.

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Part 1 How he looked

	The description	Source
Height	He was of medium height, neither very tall nor short.	Al-Bukhārī 3547, Muslim 2347
Face	The most handsome of people in face. When asked "Was his face like a sword?", al-Barāʾ said: "No, like the moon." When he was happy, his face shone as if it were a piece of the moon.	Al-Bukhārī 3549, 3552, 3556
Complexion	Neither very white nor dark: white with a touch of colour.	Al-Bukhārī 3547
Hair	Neither tightly curled nor straight, reaching between his ears and shoulders. At his death there were fewer than twenty white hairs in his head and beard.	Al-Bukhārī 3547, 3551
Hands and fragrance	Anas said: "I never touched silk softer than the palm of the Messenger of Allah ﷺ, nor smelled musk or perfume sweeter than his scent."	Al-Bukhārī 3561, Muslim 2330
The seal of prophethood	Between his shoulders, like the egg of a pigeon, the colour of his body.	Muslim 2344, 2346
His walk	He walked firmly and briskly, leaning forward, as if descending a slope.	At-Tirmidhī, ash-Shamāʾil

Jābir ibn Samurah said: "I saw the Messenger of Allah ﷺ on a moonlit night, wearing a red garment, and I began looking at him and at the moon. To me he was more beautiful than the moon" (at-Tirmidhī, 2811).

Part 2 His character

Quality	What the Companions saw
Gentleness	Anas served him for ten years: “He never once said to me ‘uff’, nor ‘why did you do that?’, nor ‘why did you not do that?’” (al-Bukhārī 6038, Muslim 2309).
Never violent	“He never struck anyone with his hand, not a woman nor a servant, except when fighting in the path of Allah” (Muslim, 2328).
Shyness (ḥayāʾ)	“He was shyer than a virgin girl in her private room. When he disliked something, we knew it from his face” (al-Bukhārī 3562, Muslim 2320).
Generosity	“He was the most generous of people, and most generous in Ramaḍān” (al-Bukhārī, 6). “He was never asked for anything and said no” (al-Bukhārī 6034, Muslim 2311).
Courage	One night Madinah heard a frightening noise. The people set out towards it and met the Prophet ﷺ already returning, on a horse without a saddle, saying: “Do not be afraid” (al-Bukhārī 2820, Muslim 2307).
Ease	“Whenever he was given a choice between two things, he chose the easier, as long as it was not a sin. And he never took revenge for himself, unless the sanctity of Allah was violated” (al-Bukhārī 3560, Muslim 2327).
Smiling	“I never saw anyone who smiled more than the Messenger of Allah ﷺ” (at-Tirmidhī, 3641).
Humility	“Do not exaggerate in praising me as the Christians exaggerated about the son of Maryam. I am only a servant, so say: the servant of Allah and His Messenger” (al-Bukhārī, 3445). A man trembled before him; he said: “Be at ease. I am not a king; I am the son of a woman of Quraysh who ate dried meat” (Ibn Mājah, 3312).

Part 3 How he spoke

- He spoke clearly and slowly, “so that if someone wanted to count his words, he could” (al-Bukhārī 3567, Muslim 2493).
- He would repeat an important word three times so that it was understood (al-Bukhārī, 95).
- He was never obscene, never cursed and never insulted people (al-Bukhārī, 3559).
- He joked, but said only the truth (at-Tirmidhī, 1990). An old woman asked him to pray that she enter Paradise; he said, smiling: “Old women will not enter Paradise”, and when she wept he explained that Allah will make them young again (at-Tirmidhī, ash-Shamāʾil).
- He listened fully: when he turned to someone, he turned his whole body towards him.

Part 4 At home

ʿĀʾishah was asked what he did at home. She said: “He would be in the service of his family, and when the time of prayer came, he went out to pray” (al-Bukhārī, 676). She also said: “He used to

mend his own sandals, sew his own clothes and work in his house as any of you works in his house" (Aḥmad).

- "The best of you are those who are best to their families, and I am the best of you to my family" (at-Tirmidhī, 3895).
- He raced ʿĀʾishah on a journey; she won, and years later he won and said: "This is for that one" (Abū Dāwūd, 2578).
- He drank from the place on the cup where ʿĀʾishah had drunk (Muslim, 300), and he let her watch the Abyssinians play with their spears in the masjid, shielding her, until she was the one who had had enough (al-Bukhārī, 454).
- He consulted his wives, as at al-Ḥudaybiyah, when Umm Salamah's advice resolved the crisis (al-Bukhārī, 2731).

Part 5 His worship

- He stood in prayer at night until his feet swelled. When ʿĀʾishah asked why, when Allah had forgiven him, he said: "Should I not be a grateful servant?" (al-Bukhārī 4837, Muslim 2820).
- "By Allah, I seek Allah's forgiveness and repent to Him more than seventy times a day" (al-Bukhārī, 6307).
- "He remembered Allah at all times" (Muslim, 373).
- He fasted Mondays and Thursdays, and three days of every month, and kept twelve sunnah rakʿahs every day and night, with witr.
- In the prayer he wept quietly, "with a sound like a boiling pot" (Abū Dāwūd, 904). Hearing Ibn Masʿūd recite an-Nisāʾ, his eyes flowed with tears (al-Bukhārī, 5050).

A day in his life

Time	What he did
Before dawn	The night prayer and witr, then a short rest.
Fajr	Two light sunnah rakʿahs, then the prayer in the masjid.
After Fajr	He sat in his place remembering Allah until the sun had risen well (Muslim, 670), then often spoke with the Companions.
Morning	Ḍuḥā prayer sometimes (Muslim, 719); teaching, receiving delegations, judging between people, and his family's needs.
Midday	Ẓuhr, and a short midday rest (qaylūlah).
Afternoon	ʿAṣr, then visiting his wives one by one (al-Bukhārī, 5216).
Evening	Maghrib, then ʿIshāʾ. He disliked sleeping before ʿIshāʾ and talking after it without need (al-Bukhārī, 568).
Bedtime	Wuḍūʾ, lying on his right side, reciting the Muʿawwidhāt and the adhkār of sleep.

Part 6 His food, dress and sleep

- "He never criticised any food. If he liked it he ate it, and if he disliked it he left it" (al-Bukhārī 3563, Muslim 2064).
- He ate with three fingers and licked them afterwards (Muslim, 2032), said Bismillāh before eating and praised Allah after.
- ʿĀʾishah said: "A month would pass and no fire was lit in our houses for cooking; it was only dates and water" (al-Bukhārī 6459, Muslim 2972).
- He slept on a mat of palm fibre that left marks on his side. ʿUmar wept, thinking of Kisrā and Caesar; he said: "Are you not pleased that they have this world and we have the Hereafter?" (al-Bukhārī 4913, Muslim 1479).
- He loved white clothes (Abū Dāwūd, 3878), wore what was available, and wore a silver ring engraved "Muḥammad Rasūl Allāh" (al-Bukhārī, 5877).
- He loved good fragrance, and loved to begin with the right in everything (al-Bukhārī, 168).

Part 7 With children, the poor and animals

With	What he did
Children	He kissed his grandson al-Ḥasan. A man said: "I have ten children and have never kissed one." He said: "Whoever does not show mercy will not be shown mercy" (al-Bukhārī 5997, Muslim 2318). He greeted children when passing them (al-Bukhārī, 6247), prayed carrying his granddaughter Umāmah (al-Bukhārī, 516), and shortened the prayer when he heard a baby cry (al-Bukhārī, 707).
The poor and weak	He accepted invitations from anyone, even to a meal of trotters (al-Bukhārī, 2568). He asked about a black woman who used to clean the masjid; when told she had died, he went and prayed at her grave (al-Bukhārī 458, Muslim 956).
Servants and workers	"Your servants are your brothers. Feed them from what you eat and clothe them from what you wear" (al-Bukhārī, 30).
Animals	He told of a man forgiven for giving water to a thirsty dog (al-Bukhārī, 2363), and a woman punished for starving a cat (al-Bukhārī, 3318). He told a man whose camel was weeping from overwork: "Do you not fear Allah regarding this animal?" (Abū Dāwūd, 2549).

Part 8 With his enemies

- At aṭ-Ṭāʾif, stoned until his feet bled, he refused the angel's offer to crush the town: "I hope that Allah will bring from their descendants people who worship Allah alone" (al-Bukhārī 3231, Muslim 1795).
- Asked to curse the idolaters, he said: "I was not sent as a curser; I was sent as a mercy" (Muslim, 2599).

- At the Opening of Makkah, he forgave the people who had persecuted him for twenty years.
- A Jewish woman of Khaybar poisoned his food; he did not take revenge for himself (al-Bukhārī, 2617).
- He was just even with those closest to him: "If Fāṭimah the daughter of Muḥammad stole, I would cut off her hand" (al-Bukhārī 3475, Muslim 1688).

Part 9 Loving him and following him

إِنَّ اللَّهَ وَمَلَائِكَتَهُ يُصَلُّونَ عَلَى النَّبِيِّ ۚ يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا صَلُّوا عَلَيْهِ وَسَلِّمُوا تَسْلِيمًا

"Indeed, Allah and His angels send blessings upon the Prophet. O you who believe, send blessings upon him and greet him with peace."

Al-Aḥzāb 33:56.

- Love him more than yourself (al-Bukhārī, 6632), and love those he loved: his family and his Companions.
- Obey his commands and follow his Sunnah: "Whoever obeys the Messenger has obeyed Allah" (an-Nisāʾ 4:80).
- Send ṣalāh upon him often, especially on Friday: "Whoever sends one ṣalāh upon me, Allah sends ten upon him" (Muslim, 408).
- Learn his life (the sīrah) and teach it to your children.
- Defend his honour with knowledge and good character, not anger.

Test Self-test

Choose the best answer. The answers follow the questions.

1. **ʿĀʾishah described his character as:**
   a) The Torah b) The Qur'an c) The sunnah of Ibrāhīm d) Arab custom
2. **Anas served the Prophet ﷺ for ten years and was never told:**
   a) "Uff" or "why did you do that?" b) Salām c) Jazāk Allāhu khayran d) To pray
3. **He was asked for something and:**
   a) Often refused b) Never said no c) Asked for payment d) Delayed it
4. **What did he do at home?**
   a) Only rested b) Served his family and mended his things c) Only received guests d) Only taught
5. **Why did he pray until his feet swelled?**
   a) To be seen b) To be a grateful servant c) To make up missed prayers d) For exercise

6. How did he treat food he disliked?

a) Criticised it b) Threw it away c) Left it without criticising d) Ate it anyway

7. "Whoever does not show mercy will not be shown mercy" was said about:

a) Kissing children b) Charity c) Animals d) Prayer

8. At aṭ-Ṭāʾif he asked Allah to:

a) Destroy the town b) Bring believers from their descendants c) Send rain d) Punish their leaders

9. How many times a day did he seek forgiveness?

a) Once b) Three times c) More than seventy times d) Only at night

10. Whoever sends one ṣalāh upon him receives from Allah:

a) One b) Ten c) A hundred d) Nothing

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	b) The Qur'an	6	c) Left it without criticising
2	a) "Uff" or "why…?"	7	a) Kissing children
3	b) Never said no	8	b) Believers from their descendants
4	b) Served his family	9	c) More than seventy times
5	b) To be a grateful servant	10	b) Ten

For further study

- **Ash-Shamā'il al-Muḥammadiyyah** of Imām at-Tirmidhī, with a commentary.
- **Ash-Shifā** of al-Qāḍī ʿIyāḍ, the great Mālikī scholar, on the rights and qualities of the Prophet ﷺ.
- Our free guides **The Makkan Years** and **The Battles of the Prophet ﷺ**.

Duʿāʾ Aṣ-Ṣalāt al-Ibrāhīmiyyah

اللَّهُمَّ صَلِّ عَلَى مُحَمَّدٍ وَعَلَى آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ، كَمَا صَلَّيْتَ عَلَى إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَعَلَى آلِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ، إِنَّكَ حَمِيدٌ مَجِيدٌ

"O Allah, send prayers upon Muḥammad and the family of Muḥammad, as You sent prayers upon Ibrāhīm and the family of Ibrāhīm. You are Praiseworthy, Glorious."

Al-Bukhārī (3370), Muslim (406).

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His character was the Qur’an.

This free booklet from the Himaayah Madrasah describes the Prophet ﷺ as his Companions saw him, so that we may know him, love him and follow him.

- How he looked, and how he spoke
- At home with his family, and a day in his life
- His worship, his food, his dress and his sleep
- With children, the poor, animals and his enemies
- Loving him and following him, and a self-test

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